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TO: All CNERG Graduate RA's
RE: Research Assistant Guidelines

A research assistant appointment should have many of the qualities of a professional position, including both its responsibilities and privileges. The Computational Nuclear Engineering Research Group [CNERG] should be a collegial environment for the sharing of research ideas and accomplishments. This can only be achieved by everyone working under the same expectations in the pursuit of the same goals. These guidelines define a professional standard of conduct intended to ensure this common direction in the activities of the research group.

Research Progress

You are expected to make steady progress towards your research goals at all times. Part of that process includes being active in setting short and medium term goals including milestone dates and deliverables. During the academic semester, performing well in your courses is certainly important, but should not cause a complete lack of productivity. This is your primary responsibility as a research assistant and the following guidelines are intended to support this responsibility.

Literature Review

An important part of being a successful researcher is understanding the work that has already been done in your field and finding a place for your research in that body of research. Learning to use the literature review tools to locate relevant articles and then reading those articles will not only provide you with valuable research skills, but will also guide your research to ensure it can be an original contributions. Finally, reading other people's published work will lead to improved writing skills. A goal of reading one publication per month is a good minimum standard.

Publications

Journal publications are the most important way to share your knowledge and creativity with the rest of the scientific community. Students pursuing a Masters degree will be expected to author or make major contributions to at least one journal paper submission. Students pursuing a doctoral degree will be expected to author at least two journal papers submissions.

Conference Submissions and Travel

You are encouraged to submit your work to technical conferences and will receive reasonable support to travel to at least one conference per year. Travel to ANS National meetings will be

organized in conjunction with the UW-ANS Student Section. Support for travel to other professional technical meetings can be arranged as necessary. Travel to ANS Student conferences will generally not be supported.

*An updated version on Dr. Wilson's website can be found here <https://cnerg.github.io/community/manual/expectations.html> along with related information in the "Manual" menu.

Professional Development

There are many individual skills and tools that are used to be a successful and efficient computational scientist. In most cases, the time investment to learn a new skill is quickly rewarded by an improvement in the quality or efficiency of your research. You are encouraged to use your research time to pursue new skills, computational or otherwise, that will support your research progress.

Meeting attendance

In order to make productive contributions to the group you are required to attend and actively participate in all CNERG meetings. These meetings are an important opportunity for all CNERG members to learn about and identify new connections to other members' research. Furthermore, by being an active participant in the research group, you can share your experience and expertise to improve the quality of all the projects being pursued by the group.

Seminars

The Engineering Physics department conducts a regular seminar series with a wide range of topics from all the research areas of the department. These seminars are generally scheduled on Tuesday afternoons at 4 PM and you should receive notification from the department office. All graduate students in the EP department are expected to attend these seminars. While it may be tempting to dismiss some topics as unrelated to your work, this is an opportunity to learn about a wide variety of interesting research. More importantly, it is common to find connections to your own work, even if they are weak connections, and in so doing you will develop a deeper understanding of the work you are pursuing.

Office Hours

Choosing when you will spend time in the office as a professional is a matter of finding a balance between your personal work habits and being available to your advisor and colleagues for impromptu meetings and consultations. Please establish some regular work-day hours when you can generally be found in your office.

Vacation

Your research assistant appointment does not include any formal vacation, sick, holiday or other leave. That said, you are permitted to take a reasonable amount of time for all of these purposes. Approximately two weeks of vacation per year is considered reasonable. As a professional, you

should consider how much additional vacation time will interrupt your ability to make progress with your research.

Quarterly Review

A private meeting at the beginning and end of each academic semester will provide an opportunity to review your research progress and performance as a researcher under the guidelines described here. This will also provide you a time to provide feedback to me on my role as an advisor.

Duties of your Advisor

You have a right to the following from me as your advisor:

- Maintenance/support of your research tools and environment to maximize your research progress,
- Timely review of your research products,
- Open access to my time to address questions and obstacles to your research,
- Constructive assessment of the quality and progress of your research,
- Flexibility in accommodating individual circumstances, and
- Opportunities for you to provide feedback on my role as an advisor.